Humble Beginnings

IT IS FASCINATING how computers, and the digital devices that they power, have evolved. I fondly remember my first stint with computers. It was in the late 80s when I saw my first IBM Mainframe at my father's office in London. I was completely amazed with the machine. I was told that this "server" ran applications for the company's computers located all across the globe, but yet all I could see was a box that whirred and clicked. Still, I was fascinated, and remain addicted to such "boxes" even today.

Now, most of what I know of the early age computer and electricity is all bookish learning. I remember the last 25 years of personal computing somewhat clearly. It started with the launch of IBM's 5100 and 5150, which were sold for about $1500, and ran 4.77 MHz processors, with 64 KB of RAM.

The first computing machine I ever touched and worked (or played) on was the good old Commodore 64, back in 1987. I also owned a Sinclair ZX Spectrum around the same time. After spending months trying to figure out those machines, I finally taught myself how to play games and use small applications.

A few years after that, my dad bought my first PC—the IBM XT 286, with an Intel 80286, 6 MHz processor, 640 KB of RAM and a 20 MB Hard Drive. I was in heaven.

Later, I got a 486, and became the school whiz-kid, because I was the first to learn of an application called Stacker that could double hard drive capacities by compressing the contents. Thanks to me, the few others in school with computers were able to store 40 MB of data on our 20 MB drives.

While I was using computers, writing programs and playing *Paratrooper*, the age of viruses hit us. We, the geeky ones at school, were petrified of viruses like Stone, Michael Angelo, Jerusalem, Raindrop and Joshi.

Those were the days of CUI. Then the doors closed and world of Windows opened. I spent months playing around with Windows 3.11, an tamed that too. As time passed, the PC evolved at breakneck speeds, and I soon found myself using Open Source software, and even wrote my first code to get on the development tree of a version of the Linux kernel. I grew up a geek, long before it was cool to be one.

Sujay Nair Editorial Director

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Today, computers are ubiquitous, and not something that's restricted to the geeky amongst us. However, even today, kids are learning to do things with computers that their peers marvel at. *Digit* gets scores of emails every month, telling us how, over the past 7 years, we've helped students become the teachers—teaching their parents, peers, and even their teachers, about technology. This month we're celebrating 7 years of being India's number one technology magazine, and are showcasing the *7 Wonders Of The Technology World*. To me, the most important Wonder is the 7th in our list, and you'll understand what I'm saying better after you've read the cover story.

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